



Grade 8 SS History

2. Deep Level Mining in South Africa

Learning Guide

1: The Randlords and the Formation of the Chamber of Mines

- It was **too expensive** for individuals to operate a gold mine alone.
- Mining required:
 - **New technologies**
 - **Costly machinery**
 - Large amounts of **capital**
- Leadership came from a small group of men:
 - **Cecil John Rhodes**
 - **Barney Barnato**
 - **Alfred Beit**
- These men:
 - Had made fortunes from **diamonds**
 - Formed **partnerships**
 - Created **mining companies**
 - Became known as the **Randlords**
- Randlords:
 - Provided the **capital** to start mines
 - Made **business decisions**
 - Aimed to **maximize profits**

Formation of the Chamber of Mines (1899)

- Mine owners joined together to form the **Chamber of Mines**.
- They worked out strategies for:
 - **Finding workers**
 - **Keeping wages low**
 - **Persuading the government** to pass laws in their favour
- Profits were **taxed**, with tax paid to the **Transvaal government**

2: Migrant Workers

- Migrant workers:
 - Travelled **long distances** to the mines
 - Worked for a **few months**
 - Then returned home
- They:
 - Lived in **rural areas**
 - Worked in **urban areas**
 - Were called "**men of two worlds**" because they lived two different lives
- Differences between workers:
 - **White miners** could settle with their families in **Johannesburg**
 - **Black workers** were forced into **migrant labour**
- The **closed compound system** from Kimberley:
 - Was used again on the **Witwatersrand gold mines**
 - To house **black mine workers**

Systematic Control of Migrant Workers

1. Taxes

- Africans had to pay:
 - **Hut tax:** R1 per year per hut
 - **Poll tax:** R2 per year for every man over 18
- Wages:
 - Black workers earned **5c to 19c per day**
 - Took **months of extra work** just to pay the poll tax

2. Recruitment

- Workers:
 - Travelled long distances **on foot**
 - Often arrived **exhausted and injured**
 - Faced danger from **robbers and crooks**
- Some refused to work after arriving.
- The **Chamber of Mines:**
 - Sent **agents** to villages
 - Worked with **African chiefs**
 - **Persuaded men** to work in mines
 - **Escorted workers** to prevent them from going elsewhere

3. Contracts

- Workers had to sign contracts:
 - Usually **6 to 18 months**
- Workers:
 - Had to remain on the mine until the contract ended
- Breaking contracts led to:
 - **Arrest**
 - **Fines**
 - **Jail**

4. Pass Laws

- Introduced by the **Transvaal government** working with mine owners.
- A black man:
 - Needed a **pass** to look for work
 - Had **3 days** to find a job
- If unsuccessful:
 - Had to **leave**
 - Or be **forced to work in mines** where:
 - Wages were low
 - Conditions were harsh

After Work in the Mines

- Workers returned home with goods like:
 - Watches, clothes, boots, blankets, tools, etc.
- They still had to pay:
 - **Tax to the chief**
 - **Hut tax**
 - **Poll tax**

3: Burden on Women and Erosion of Families

Labour Reserves

- Rural areas became **labour reserves:**
 - Places supplying workers to mines and factories
- Problems:
 - **Severe soil erosion**
 - Farming became difficult

Impact on Women

- More men left to work in mines.
- Women had to:
 - **Take over men's work**
 - Work under **poor conditions**
- Rural areas became:
 - **Poorer and poorer**

Reserves Become Poorer

- Less farmland available (taken by **white settlers**)
- Soil quality declined → **less food**
- Cattle became thin → **less milk**
- Families:
 - Had to **buy goods** from trading stores
 - Became dependent on **cash income**
- While:
 - Mines grew **richer**
 - Reserves became **poorer**

Erosion of Families

- Fathers and young men:
 - Left home for **long periods**
 - Women, children, elderly:
 - Stayed behind
 - Result:
 - **Breakdown of family life**
 - **Erosion of families**
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4: Skilled and Unskilled Workers (Racial Segregation)

- The **working class**:
 - People who sell labour for wages
 - During the Mineral Revolution:
 - **White and black workers were separated**
 - White workers:
 - Got **legal protection**
 - Did **skilled jobs**
 - Earned **higher wages**
 - Black workers:
 - Did **unskilled work**
 - Earned **lower wages**
 - This system was based on:
 - **Racism** (false belief that some races are superior)
 - Result:
 - Foundation for **racial segregation in South Africa**
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5: Anti-Indian Legislation

- Indians came to South Africa from **1860 onward** and later moved to the **Witwatersrand**.
- The Transvaal government:
 - Passed **discriminatory laws** to stop them settling

Key Laws

- No **citizenship rights** → could not vote
- Had to live in **designated areas**
- Needed a **trading license**
- Had to carry **passes at all times**

- Treated as **labourers** like African populations
 - No **marriage with whites**
 - Not allowed to work in **gold mines**
 - Not allowed to walk on **pavements**
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6: Labour Resistance

How Workers Resisted

- **Breaking contracts** (most common)
- **Alcohol-related absenteeism**
- **Working slow / sabotage**

Reaction to Wage Cuts

- During the **South African War (1899–1902)**:
 - Mines closed
- In 1902:
 - Wages were reduced
- Workers:
 - Did **not return**
- Mine owners:
 - Brought in **Chinese labourers**
- Result:
 - **1907 strike** by white miners

Trade Unionism

- Black workers learned about unions from: **British workers' struggles**
 - They learned: Importance of **organising in groups**
 - But: It was **difficult** due to harsh conditions
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7: The City of Johannesburg

- Johannesburg:
 - Grew due to **gold mining (1886)**
 - Is now in **Gauteng Province**
 - Historical changes:
 - Part of **Boer Republic (Transvaal)**
 - Became part of **Union of South Africa (1910)**
 - Became part of **Gauteng (1994)**
 - Gauteng:
 - **Most populated province**
 - **Smallest in land area**
 - Economic centre of South Africa
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✓ Key Takeaways

- ✓ Gold mining required **large capital and technology**
 - ✓ Labour was tightly controlled through **taxes, contracts, and passes**
 - ✓ Rural areas became poorer while mines became richer
 - ✓ Families were **broken apart**
 - ✓ Racism created **unequal working conditions**
 - ✓ Workers resisted in different ways
 - ✓ Johannesburg developed because of **gold mining**
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